

Ashesi

Guide

CV WRITING

Learn how
to craft a
winning CV!

THE BONES

First things first – *Alignment and aesthetics*

While this may seem trivial, the appearance of your CV can disqualify you before the content is read.

The Ashesi CV template is structured to be easy for the eye to follow. The left and right borders are properly aligned to easily lead the reader's eyes down and across the CV.

As you edit this template, ensure you do not:

1. Mess up the horizontal lines
2. Change the font (if you copy text from somewhere, e.g. LinkedIn URL, make sure you correct the font)
3. If you somehow mess up the alignment, go to the view tab and check the "rulers" option at the top right (insert image)

The ruler allows you to align the content of each line of your Word document individually using the handles at the top of your page.

CV length

While you are a student, keep your CV within the **1-page limit** when submitting it for your applications.

Of course, you may have more experiences than 1 page can contain. That is fine. We recommend that every student have a **Master CV** containing all their previous experiences. It can span as many pages as necessary. It will serve as a repository from which you can pick tailored/relevant experiences to suit the opportunities you are applying to. For example, if you are applying for a business analyst role, you will pick enough relevant experiences to address the job description (both hard and soft skills).

A lengthy CV is prone to redundancy, is not concise, and is more draining to read. Recruiters would likely spend less than 5 seconds on a resume. If you don't strike the right chords quickly, you will be discarded from the set of options in way less time than you took packing your CV.

Fonts

Please do not change the template font size and font face to force your content to fit within 1 page. Instead, review your experiences to ensure they are as concise and relevant as possible. A few tips on how to trim will be shared in another section of this manual.

Font: Verdana Font size: 8.5

Bullet Points

- Do not change the bullet points in the template to anything fancy. Maintain the dots; they are easy to follow.
- Ensure all the dots are aligned throughout your CV.

Titles

The titles for your experiences should be in **bold** and left-aligned. The dates for

each of them should be right-aligned and bold.

***Caution:** This template already has dates. Edit the dates before your recruiter sees something like...*

“Ashesi Innovation Experience

August 2014”

whereas you claim to have joined Ashesi in 2026

Consistency

Consistency keeps the mind engaged and feeds specific things to readers. If you choose to abbreviate your dates, e.g. Aug 2020, Sep 2015, etc., abbreviate all dates throughout your CV. Other aspects of consistency have already been addressed, such as alignment and point icons.



THE MEAT

Hopefully, by now, you are clear on how your resume should look regarding formatting. Up next is the content.

***NB:** For the following sections of this guide, we recommend reading one at a time and editing accordingly rather than reading the whole guide before starting. You can split your screen and read while you edit.*

• Header

The first thing on your CV is your Name (font-face: Verdana, font-size: 14) followed by your addresses (postal address, phone number, nationality, email addresses (ashesi and personal email), LinkedIn URL, website/GitHub URL if available)

Your LinkedIn URL should contain your first and last names with no trailing characters (generated by default when you create your account). If yours still has them:

1. Sign in to your LinkedIn account
2. Go to profile (insert image)
3. Click on me at the top right of your window
4. Select view profile
5. Click the pencil icon next to the Public Profile & URL section (insert image) and delete the extra numbers. Save, and you're done. You can transfer your edited URL to your CV now.

• Education

University and Senior High School suffice. SHS can be taken out after your second year, especially when space is needed for more relevant experiences that are more recent than high school. You are expected to have done other things in the 2 years since you started university.

Every other detail for this section involves formatting, which has already been discussed.

***NB:** You can include at most 6 courses if they are **VERY RELEVANT** to the position you are going for.*

• Achievements and Awards

Includes scholarships, awards from competitions, recognition for different endeavours, etcetera. Note that getting a position is not an award, though achievements can be obtained through them. These are better discussed under the co-curricular activities section.

• Work Experiences

Undoubtedly, it is one of the most critical yet most confusing parts of your CV. In the past years reviewing students' CVs, it was noticed that many students face difficulties with this section mainly for the following reasons:

1. Many students believe they have no work experience
2. Students don't often know what qualifies as work experience
3. Often, students think only of internships and jobs with companies

To ease things for you, work and experience encompass all forms of work, formal or informal, within a given domain. Being a financial analyst for Goldman Sachs is not more work experience than being a salesperson for a family business or local venture. Being a software engineer at Google is as much work experience as being a web developer for a friend's business that probably no one knows at the moment.

The purpose of work experiences on your CV is to display relevant skills and aptitudes required for the opportunity you are interested in and to show a degree of conversance with the specific job and working in a professional environment.

Thus, consider all your experiences, be they for family businesses, companies, work studies, and even for private individuals.

How to Frame Work Experiences

Imagine walking into a mall over the weekend to buy food supplies. You walk to the fruits and vegetables section to buy a few apples. You see two sets of apples. The first has leaf green apples with no blemishes stacked in a beautiful pyramidal structure. The second has green apples with darker spots poured out in a tray. Both sets have the exact cost per apple. Which set would you pick from?

Per your personal inclinations, you could pick from any of the sets. After all, they have the same vitamins in them. Nonetheless, an average person would choose from the more good-looking set.

Two students may have the same qualifications but present them differently. Whoever presents themselves best will have the upper hand.

Work experiences, just like most of the sections on your CV, should be ordered in reversed chronology. This means that the most recent relevant experiences should come first. Recruiters want to know what you've been up to recently first. Generally, the more recent an experience is, the more likely you are to perform well at it. More so, recent experiences will be strengthened by older

related ones, hence boosting them on the premises of consistency. See the template for the writing format.

The actual packaging of work experiences is done through the framing of your points. You want to show the recruiters how capable you have been and still are through the points under each work experience. To this end, every point should be written as an **Accomplishment Statement**. An accomplishment statement boasts of your achievements from working by describing a relevant task executed during the experience, highlighting its relevance and impact on the setting where the experience happened.

Accomplishment Statements generally have three components:

1. **The What:** What did you do? What was the task or activity performed, e.g.

“Tutored 5 freshmen twice a week for a period of 6 months”

Throughout your accomplishment statement, you want to give numeric details where possible to add context and credibility.

2. **The Why and/or The How:** What was the purpose of what you did? Why was it relevant? In some cases, the why might be obvious, so you may want to avoid redundancy, e.g.

“Cleaned the school floor to keep the floor clean”

This is quite a sketchy example, but you get the point. In such cases, you may consider turning towards the how. How did you achieve the what? What was different about your approach? Many times, the how carries more weight than the what by revealing pieces of your approach to problem-solving or giving more support to the what and/or why by qualifying your approach, e.g.

“Ensured optimal hygienic conditions by dividing school premises into sectors and monitoring patterns in individual sectors to devise efficient cleaning roasters them”

Another sketchy rip-off of the previous example, but I hope you get the point 😊.

3. The Result/Outcome: You've done things and told us why and how you did them. What were the results? Was it all in vain? Or did you make an impact on your workspace, clients, school, family business, etc? An example based on the previous one:

“Divided school premises into sectors and monitored patterns in their hygiene to devise efficient cleaning rosters for each sector reducing weekly cleaning time by 20% while maintaining quality”

This statement highlights data collection and analysis skills, quality of work, and systems thinking. It sure does not sound like the latest business internship, but it still portrays skills that are relevant to the field.

You certainly have done more interesting things than the previous example. Do not undermine the things you have done so far. Consider the points below when you face difficulties figuring out your work experiences or framing them:

- What skills are required for the job?
- What have I done in the past months or vacations?
- What am I currently doing at school?
- What skills were involved in what I did?
- Are there any skills in what I have done so far that match the job description?

These questions will help you match the skills you need to show to the ones you presently have in your experiences and inform the structure of your points. Sometimes, reframing the skills involved can do great good, e.g. “data analysis” could be reframed as “the ability to find patterns in information.” Moreover, you can always visit your career advisor or career guides and chat with them to help you figure things out.

To conclude this section, here are a few more tips:

- Remain as concise as possible. Avoid redundancy.
- Use synonyms of words to avoid reusing them too often.
- Start your points with verbs that address what you did. Avoid verbs like helped and assisted, which do not tell exactly what you did. In some rare cases, assist will be the correct verb, but don't abuse it!
- Never...Never use personal pronouns. E.g. I recorded data... We managed... Please always start with verbs and action words.
- It is recommended to keep your points in one sentence. Avoid using full stops to end a point and add explanations for the outcomes or results in

another sentence. e.g.

“Recorded and analysed experimental data to identify correlations between substances A and B. We found out that substance A increases as substance B decreases.”

Avoid this. Follow the accomplishment statement format. Give just enough details and have faith that you will have more room to explain when called for an interview.

***.NB:** Each work experience should have roughly the same number of points for balance. This also applies to projects and research.*

• Projects and Research

The Accomplishment statement format also applies here. Any projects and research (personal, group, or school-based) are welcome. This section allows you to showcase relevant technical knowledge in the application and helps recruiters understand your interests and scope of work. Depending on your major, projects will have different metrics for success and different ways of presenting outcomes. BA might draw outcomes based on business KPIs, while the more tech-inclined majors may consider outcomes such as power consumption, responsiveness, optimisation, etc. You know best 😊

• Co-curricular Activities

What do you do outside the classroom besides sleeping and watching movies :)? Here, you are welcome to share the interests in which you are actively involved. This could be the section that would set you apart from other applicants doing the same course as you. Do you play an instrument, write in your free time, actively engage with a club, or volunteer your skills over the weekend? This is your time to shine. State your involvement in the other sections of your CV and briefly share what you do in each. e.g.

- Ashesi Football Association
- Graphic Designer

Plan and design breath-taking visuals in line with the AFA brand and maintain social media engagement at high levels weekly (could be numerical data, e.g. maintain social media engagement above 90% weekly).

Here, you can be more lenient on the accomplishment statement format but be as concise as possible and provide clear information about your engagements.

• Skills & Interests

Ideally, this section captures the skills you did not have space to show on your CV, mainly hard skills such as software you know how to use, languages you speak, etc. Soft skills are to be seen through your experiences. Either you show them there or show them there. Don't say you pay attention to detail after spelling attention with one "t" as I did earlier.

“Talk is cheap.” But sometimes
talk is all you have time to do.

”

Don't say you are good at working with teams when none of your experiences indicated that you worked in a team. Don't say you have accounting skills while applying for a business job when none of your experiences can back it up. Let your CV show the skills, especially the soft ones, and the skills section will handle the hard skills you could not discuss.



The Conclusion

References

You can remove this section if you need more space. Recruiters will ask for references whether this section is there or not if they need it.

Voila! You are good to go. You should have written your first CV by now. Go through the guide quickly to ensure you got everything right before submitting it for review at the Career Services office or on [College Central Network](#).

Feel free to go through specific sections again after editing your CV the first few times. You won't really need to use this guide again after a few reviews. All the best, and see you at the office.

CONGRATS!

You should be a Sensei in CV writing now! Watch the Resume Writing Video and use all the resources provided to you to craft a winning CV.

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REVIEW!

Visit the Career Services Office (Radichel Hall 203 A) to meet with a Career Peer Advisor to review your newly crafted CV.



Career
Services